



# A golden night

Lionel Messi led Inter Miami to its **maiden** MLS Cup title.

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**W**hen the final whistle blew on December 6, Chase Stadium looked consumed by a tsunami of pink towels and jerseys.

Javier Mascherano, now a victorious coach, kissed the grass and ran onto the pitch as if it were another of his playing nights at Camp Nou. And Lionel Messi, the star of the show, was embraced and applauded as if he belonged only to Miami.

**Inter Miami had just beaten Vancouver Whitecaps 3-1 to win its first-ever Major League Soccer (MLS) Cup — the American top-flight title.**

A team that had questions raised over tactics, players — anyone but Messi — and management after a disappointing Club World Cup campaign earlier this year finally had its moment of glory. The critics were silenced, and any room for doubt was

glazed with confetti and winners' medals.

Messi was the key to all three goals in the final: he set up two, delivered a crucial pass for the other — the opening strike, an own goal — and won the league's Most Valuable Player (MVP) award for the second time in a row, a first for any player in MLS.

Tadeo Allende's cross, after a hoofed ball from Messi, was steered into the net by a retreating Edier Ocampo in the eighth minute, but the Whitecaps restored parity at the hour mark when Ali Ahmed's scuffed shot sneaked past Rocco Rios' arm.

Messi spurred into action immediately, and within 11 minutes it was 2-1 to Miami. He won the ball off Andrés Cubas and threaded a through ball for Rodrigo De Paul, who slotted it past Yohei Takaoka.

In stoppage time, Messi's magic yielded a third — his lobbed pass was received well by Allende, who then finished calmly to add a chef's kiss to a

dominant performance.

The match had several subplots: Thomas Muller, who once rejoiced on a harrowing night for Messi after their Bayern Munich versus Barcelona clash in the Champions League — which ended in an 8-2 win for Bayern — now stood on the losing end.

**The match was an exhibition of Argentine football's prosperity blended with a flavour of Miami.** All players with goals and assists for Miami (except the own goal), as well as the head coach, came from Argentina, gelling seamlessly with American soccer and its players to script history for Miami. The match also marked the end of an era for Inter Miami at Chase Stadium, which has been its home since its inception in 2020.

The club will begin its next season at Miami Freedom Park — the team's newly constructed home.

Messi and Co. will be relieved that the farewell ended with a smile — and a broad one at that.